Critical Thinking Syllabus

Upper Homeschool

2026–2027

INSTRUCTOR INFORMATION

Instructor	Email	Room Location & Hours
Dan Hegelund	Dan@rivertech.me	Dance Hall — Thursdays, 11:05–11:45 AM

GENERAL INFORMATION

Description

This is a four-quarter, book-based critical-thinking course for upper homeschool students. Each quarter has its own theme and guiding question — Think Clearly, Evaluate Viewpoints & Evidence, Investigate Evidence, and Test Ideas & Solve Problems — moving from the basics of arguments and reasoning through evidence literacy, investigation, and finally testing ideas scientifically. The course arc runs: ask better questions → evaluate evidence → test ideas → solve problems.

Course Rhythm

Each quarter runs seven core teaching weeks; the remaining weeks are intentionally left open for tests, recap, games, missed classes, projects, debates, or deeper discussion. The book is a thinking laboratory — not a race to finish pages.

COURSE MATERIALS

Required Materials

- The critical-thinking course book (provided by the instructor)
- Something to write with, for weekly reading questions

QUARTER 1: THINK CLEARLY

How do I know what I actually think — and whether my reasoning makes sense?

Foundation: arguments, facts and inferences, reasons, premises, conclusions, self-critique, and pausing before reacting.

Thursday due dates, 2026. Complete the reading and questions before class. Quarterly assessment: Week 7.

Week / Due	Lesson(s)	Pages	Critical-Thinking Focus	Homework Due
1 — Sept. 10	Lesson 1 — A Thinking Tool	14–20	What critical thinking is; thinking as a skill and a tool	Read pp. 14–20 and answer the questions.
2 — Sept. 17	Lessons 2–3 — Discussion, Disagreement, Argument, Fight / When It Is Dumb to Argue	21–31	What an argument is; when reasoning is useful and when arguing is pointless	Read pp. 21–31 and answer the questions.
3 — Sept. 24	Lesson 4 — Fact, Inference, or Opinion	32–41	Separate what is observed, concluded, and believed	Read pp. 32–41 and answer the questions.
4 — Oct. 1	Lesson 5 — Finding the Premises and Conclusion	42–49	Identify the structure of an argument	Read pp. 42–49 and answer the questions.
5 — Oct. 8	Lesson 6 — How to List Reasons Why You Believe Something	50–59	Give reasons instead of merely asserting opinions	Read pp. 50–59 and answer the questions.
6 — Oct. 15	Lesson 7 — How to Defeat Your Own Argument	60–67	Test your own position; practice intellectual honesty	Read pp. 60–67 and answer the questions.
7 — Oct. 22	Lesson 8 — How to Take a "STOP" Moment	68–73	Slow down before reacting, arguing, or deciding	Read pp. 68–73 and answer the questions. Written test in class.

Quarter 1 Assessment — Week 7 — October 22, 2026

A written test on arguments, facts and inferences, reasons, premises, conclusions, self-critique, and pausing before reacting.

Open week after the assessment: October 29.

QUARTER ARC

Think → distinguish → construct → challenge → pause.

By the End of This Quarter, Students Should Be Able To:

- Distinguish discussion, disagreement, argument, and fight.
- Separate facts, inferences, and opinions.
- Identify premises and conclusions in an argument.
- Give reasons for a belief and test those reasons fairly.

Course rhythm: seven core teaching weeks per quarter. Remaining weeks are intentionally open for tests, recap, games, missed classes, projects, debates, or deeper discussion. The book is a thinking laboratory — not a race to finish pages.

QUARTER 2: EVALUATE VIEWPOINTS & EVIDENCE

When people disagree, how do I decide what deserves to be believed?

Evidence literacy: opposing viewpoints, source quality, credibility, motive, bias, and corroboration.

Thursday due dates, 2026–27. Complete the reading and questions before class. Quarterly assessment: Week 7.

Week / Due	Lesson(s)	Pages	Critical-Thinking Focus	Homework Due
1 — Nov. 5	Lesson 9 — Using the Opposing Viewpoints Chart	74–81	Represent competing viewpoints clearly and fairly	Read pp. 74–81 and answer the questions.
2 — Nov. 12	Lesson 10 — Opposing Viewpoints Are Everywhere	82–88	Recognize competing claims in everyday life	Read pp. 82–88 and answer the questions.
3 — Nov. 19	Lesson 11 — The Good, the Bad, and the Ugly Evidence	89–93	Distinguish stronger evidence from weaker evidence	Read pp. 89–93 and answer the questions.
4 — Dec. 3	Lesson 12 — You Can't Believe Everything You Hear	94–100	Evaluate claims instead of accepting them automatically	Read pp. 94–100 and answer the questions.
5 — Dec. 10	Lesson 13 — Are You Primary or Secondary?	101–106	Understand primary and secondary sources	Read pp. 101–106 and answer the questions.
6 — Dec. 17	Lesson 14 — Who Has a Reason to Lie?	107–114	Consider motive, bias, credibility, and conflicts of interest	Read pp. 107–114 and answer the questions.
7 — Jan. 7	Lesson 15 — Corroborating Evidence	115–122	Use independent confirmation to strengthen a conclusion	Read pp. 115–122 and answer the questions. Essay due.

Quarter 2 Assessment — Week 7 — January 7, 2027

Write a 2–3 page essay on evaluating viewpoints and evidence, including source quality, credibility, motive, bias, and corroboration.

No school: November 26, December 24, and December 31. Open week after the assessment: January 14.

QUARTER ARC

Claim → source → evidence → credibility → corroboration.

By the End of This Quarter, Students Should Be Able To:

- Describe opposing viewpoints without caricaturing either side.
- Judge evidence by quality rather than quantity alone.
- Distinguish primary from secondary sources.
- Consider bias and motive, then look for corroboration.

Course rhythm: seven core teaching weeks per quarter. Remaining weeks are intentionally open for tests, recap, games, missed classes, projects, debates, or deeper discussion. The book is a thinking laboratory — not a race to finish pages.

QUARTER 3: INVESTIGATE EVIDENCE

How do I reason when the evidence is incomplete, uncertain, or complicated?

Investigation: conflicting testimony, possibility and probability, circumstantial evidence, observation, and generating explanations.

Thursday due dates, 2027. Complete the reading and questions before class. Quarterly assessment: Week 7.

Week / Due	Lesson(s)	Pages	Critical-Thinking Focus	Homework Due
1 — Jan. 21	Lessons 16–17 — Mystery of the Stolen Manoot / Stir Plot until Thickened	123–131	Apply evidence tools to a case and reconstruct what probably happened	Read pp. 123–131 and answer the questions.
2 — Jan. 28	Lesson 18 — Gunfight at the O.K. Corral	132–140	Compare conflicting testimony and reconstruct past events	Read pp. 132–140 and answer the questions.
3 — Feb. 4	Lessons 19–20 — Does a "Possibly" Make a "Probably"? / Circumstantial Evidence	141–155	Distinguish possibility from probability; reason from indirect evidence	Read pp. 141–155 and answer the questions.
4 — Feb. 11	Lesson 21 — Puzzling Developments	156–161	Synthesize evidence and draw careful conclusions	Read pp. 156–161 and answer the questions.
5 — Feb. 25	Lessons 22–23 — Mole the Scientist / Tools that Help Scientists Do Their Job	162–177	Move from historical investigation into scientific inquiry	Read pp. 162–177 and answer the questions.
6 — Mar. 4	Lesson 24 — How to Be a Keen Observer	178–189	Observe carefully before explaining	Read pp. 178–189 and answer the questions.
7 — Mar. 11	Lesson 25 — Brainstorming	190–197	Generate multiple possible explanations before choosing one	Read pp. 190–197 and answer the questions. Written test in class.

Quarter 3 Assessment — Week 7 — March 11, 2027

A written test on conflicting testimony, possibility and probability, circumstantial evidence, observation, and generating explanations.

No school: February 18 and April 1. Open weeks after the assessment: March 18 and March 25.

QUARTER ARC

Observe → compare evidence → estimate probability → generate explanations.

By the End of This Quarter, Students Should Be Able To:

- Reason carefully from incomplete and conflicting evidence.
- Distinguish what is possible from what is probable.
- Use circumstantial evidence without overstating certainty.
- Separate observation from explanation and generate multiple hypotheses.

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QUARTER 4: TEST IDEAS & SOLVE PROBLEMS

How do I move from a possible explanation to a conclusion I can defend?

Application: hypotheses, falsification, experiments, data, pseudoscience, projects, goals, and organizing complex ideas.

Thursday due dates, 2027. Complete the reading and questions before class. Quarterly assessment: Week 7.

Week / Due	Lesson(s)	Pages	Critical-Thinking Focus	Homework Due
1 — Apr. 8	Lessons 26–27 — Hypothesis Is a Huge Word / How to Prove You Are Wrong	198–209	Form hypotheses and try to falsify rather than merely confirm them	Read pp. 198–209 and answer the questions.
2 — Apr. 15	Lesson 28 — A Good Experiment	210–220	Design a fair test	Read pp. 210–220 and answer the questions.
3 — Apr. 22	Lesson 29 — How to Analyze Data	221–230	Interpret results and decide what the evidence supports	Read pp. 221–230 and answer the questions.
4 — Apr. 29	Lessons 30–31 — Listen and Learn / Pseudoscience	231–245	Learn from expertise while evaluating scientific claims critically	Read pp. 231–245 and answer the questions.
5 — May 6	Lessons 32–33 — Projects / The Mystery of the Large Letter Library	246–256	Apply reasoning tools to practical problems and projects	Read pp. 246–256 and answer the questions.
6 — May 13	Lesson 34 — How to Make SMART Goals	257–261	Turn an idea into a clear, actionable plan	Read pp. 257–261 and answer the questions.
7 — May 20	Lesson 35 — How to Mindmap	262–267	Organize complex thinking and communicate relationships among ideas	Read pp. 262–267 and answer the questions. Presentation due.

Quarter 4 Assessment — Week 7 — May 20, 2027

A public speaking presentation with slideshow on testing ideas and solving problems, using the critical-thinking tools from this quarter.

Open weeks after the assessment: May 27 and June 3.

COURSE ARC

Ask better questions → evaluate evidence → test ideas → solve problems.

By the End of This Quarter, Students Should Be Able To:

- Form testable hypotheses and look for ways they could be wrong.
- Design fair experiments and analyze results.
- Distinguish sound scientific reasoning from pseudoscientific claims.
- Apply critical-thinking tools to projects, goals, and complex ideas.

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